## Ancient networks

Fossils of plants dating from 400 million years ago—when vegetation was first spreading across dry land—show traces of fungal threads. This suggests that the mycorrhizal partnership was key to the evolution of terrestrial life. Today, the majority of plant species continue to rely on fungi in this way. Trees supported by mycorrhizae are more resistant to drought and disease, and can even communicate alarm signals by releasing chemicals in response to attack by herbivores. This fungal network connecting trees has been dubbed “the wood-wide web.”